Analytical Study of a Home-Based Gifts Curating Company

An End-Term report for the BDM capstone Project

Submitted by

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Declaration Statement

I am working on a Project titled "**Analytical Study of a Home-Based Gifts Curating Company"**. I extend my appreciation to **B-STORIES**, for providing the necessary resources that enabled me to conduct my project.

I hereby assert that the data presented and assessed in this project report is genuine and precise to the utmost extent of my knowledge and capabilities. The data has been gathered from primary sources and carefully analysed to assure its reliability.

Additionally, I affirm that all procedures employed for the purpose of data collection and analysis have been duly explained in this report. The outcomes and inferences derived from the data are an accurate depiction of the findings acquired through thorough analytical procedures.

I am dedicated to adhering to the principles of academic honesty and integrity, and I am receptive to any additional examination or validation of the data contained in this project report.

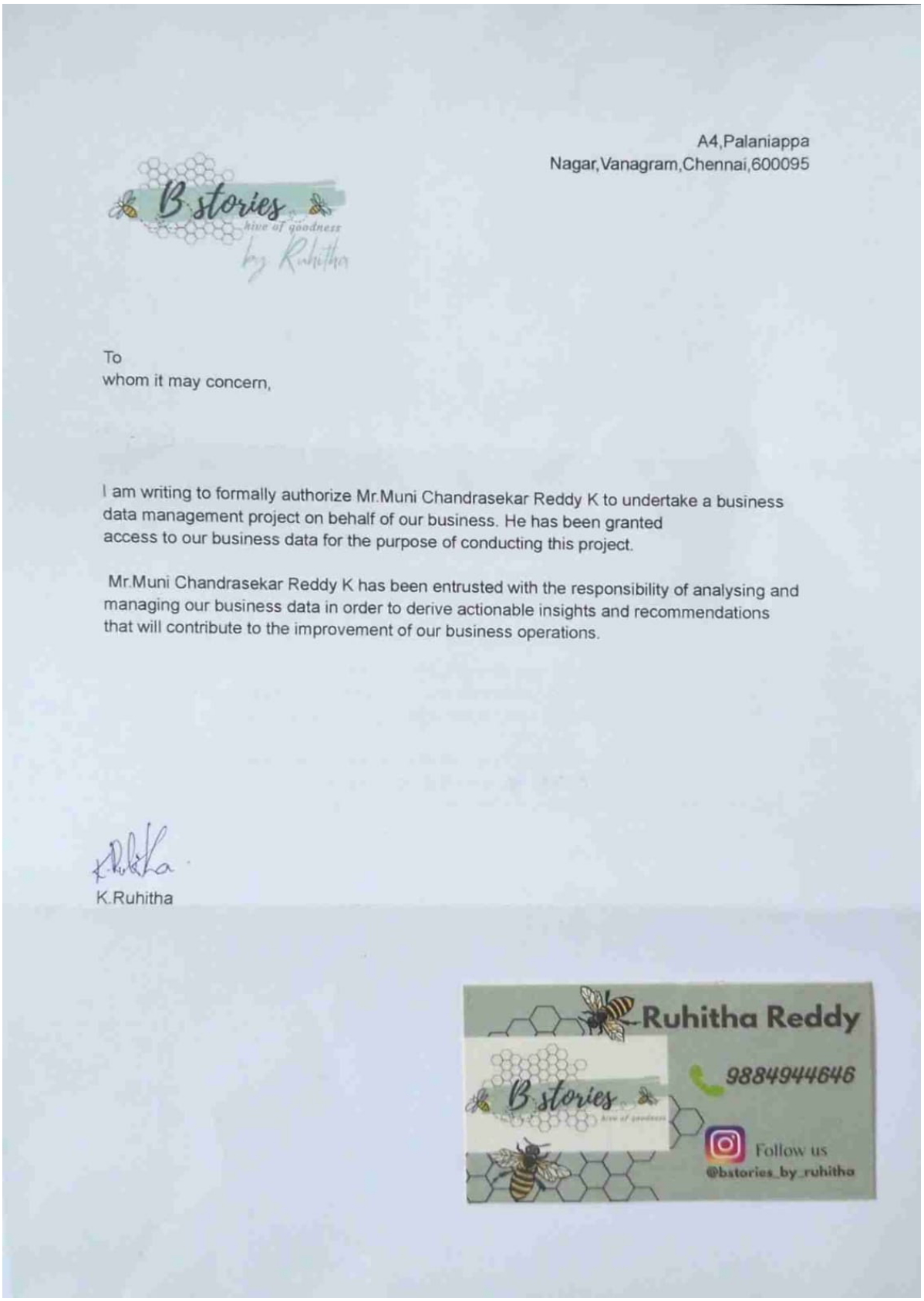
I understand that the execution of this project is intended for individual completion and is not to be undertaken collectively. I thus affirm that I am not engaged in any form of collaboration with other individuals, and that all the work undertaken has been solely conducted by me. In the event that plagiarism is detected in the report at any stage of the project's completion, I am fully aware and prepared to accept disciplinary measures imposed by the relevant authority.

I understand that all recommendations made in this project report are within the context of the academic project taken up towards course fulfilment in the BS Degree Program offered by IIT Madras. The institution does not endorse any of the claims or comments.

Signature of Candidate:

Name: Muni Chandrasekar Reddy. K

Date: 10 July 2025



A4,Palaniappa
Nagar,Vanagram,Chennai,600095

B stories
hive of goodness
by Ruhitha

To
whom it may concern,

I am writing to formally authorize Mr.Muni Chandrasekar Reddy K to undertake a business data management project on behalf of our business. He has been granted access to our business data for the purpose of conducting this project.

Mr.Muni Chandrasekar Reddy K has been entrusted with the responsibility of analysing and managing our business data in order to derive actionable insights and recommendations that will contribute to the improvement of our business operations.

K.Ruhitha

Ruhitha Reddy
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Letter of consent from owner

1 Executive Summary

Introduction:

B-Stories by Ruhitha is a home-based gifting brand in Chennai established in 2020, offers handcrafted goods such as soaps, candles, and curated hampers. While the brand has grown organically through platforms like Instagram and pop-up stores, it faces operational challenges that hinder scalability.

Challenges:

B-Stories is currently struggling with irregular demand patterns, which makes inventory management difficult and often leads to overstocking or missed sales opportunities. On the marketing front, fierce competition on Instagram has made it harder to maintain visibility and engagement. These challenges are further compounded by logistical inefficiencies, where unfulfilled delivery transactions result in wasted costs and erratic cash flow.

Project Approach:

To address these challenges, a mixed-method analysis was conducted using data from June to August 2025. The goal is to forecast sales trends, optimize inventory planning, and establish a strict payment policy to reduce delivery wastage. By implementing these strategies, B-Stories aims to establish a foundation for sustainable, data-driven growth.

2 Detailed Explanation of Analysis Process/Method

2.1. Method for Financial Overview

To provide a comprehensive view of the business's financial health, a **Financial Overview** was conducted using the weekly revenue datasets.

- **Total Turnover Calculation:** The sum of all revenue generated across the 12-week period was calculated to establish the business's gross income.
- **Volatility Metrics:** To measure the stability of income, statistical metrics including **Mean (Average)**, **Minimum**, **Maximum**, and **Standard Deviation** were computed.
    - *Standard Deviation* was specifically used to quantify the financial risk and irregularity of cash flow, highlighting the gap between "event-based" income and "regular" income.

Revenue Data:

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I	J	K	L	M	N	O
1	Name of the Item	Sale in Week-1 (Jun 2,'25 - Jun 8,'25)	Sale in Week-2 (Jun 9,'25 - Jun 15,'25)	Sale in Week-3 (Jun 16,'25 - Jun 22,'25)	Sale in Week-4 (Jun 2,'23 - Jun 29,'25)	Sale in Week-5 (Jun 30,'25 - Jul 6,'25)	Sale in Week-6 (Jul 7,'25- Jul 13,'25)	Sale in Week-7 (Jul 14,'25- Jul 20,'25)	Sale in Week-8 (Jul 21,'25- Jul 27,'25)	Sale in Week-9 (Jul 28,'25- Aug 3,'25)	Sale in Week-10 (Aug 4,'25- Aug 10,'25)	Sale in Week-11 (Aug 11,'25- Aug 17,'25)	Sale in Week-12 (Aug 18,'25- Aug 24,'25)	Total Sales per Item	
2	Large Soaps	75	150	75	0	0	300	150	0	300	225	150	150	**1575**	
3	Medium Soaps	200	200	100	0	100	350	0	100	100	100	0	100	**1350**	
4	Small Soaps	175	350	140	210	175	140	70	70	350	35	70	105	**1890**	
5	Bangle holder	200	0	0	0	400	0	200	0	200	200	0	0	**1200**	
6	andles(pack of 4)-Sma	300	600	200	500	100	1000	200	200	1300	200	300	600	**5500**	
7	andles(pack of 4)-Larg	400	1000	0	400	200	1200	0	0	600	200	200	400	**4600**	
8	candle-Type1	300	450	300	360	150	300	120	60	450	90	60	120	**2760**	
9	candle-Type2	210	490	0	210	210	560	0	0	140	70	0	70	**1960**	
10	Hamper-1 (Mini)	300	500	500	200	200	1000	0	0	500	0	0	500	**3700**	
11	Hamper-2(Small)	0	800	0	800	600	400	400	0	200	0	200	400	**3800**	
12	Hamper-3(medium)	350	1050	0	350	0	1050	350	0	0	0	350	0	**3500**	
13	Hamper-4(large)	0	1000	0	0	1500	5000	0	0	500	0	0	0	**8000**	
14	**TOTAL SALES per weel**	**2510**	**6590**	**1315**	**3030**	**3635**	**11300**	**1490**	**430**	**4640**	**1120**	**1330**	**2445**		
15															

Statistics by using MAX(),MIN(),STD(),AVERAGE(),MEDIAN() functions in Excel:

STATISTICS Per Week	
Mean	=AVERAGE(B14:M14)
Max	₹ 11,300.00
Min	₹ 430.00
Median	₹ 2,477.50
Std.Dev	₹ 3,048.72

2.2. Method for Sales and Time-Series Analysis

To address the challenge of unpredictable demand, a systematic Time-Series Analysis was undertaken on the sales data collected from the owner's diaries and Instagram logs.

- **Data Aggregation:** Sales quantities were aggregated into **weekly data points** to identify broader trends over the 12-week period.
- **Peak Identification:** The analysis isolated specific weeks with abnormally high sales to distinguish between organic online demand and event-driven demand (Pop-up stores).

Week		Total Revenue
Sale in Week-1	(Jun 2,'25 - Jun 8,'25)	2510
Sale in Week-2	(Jun 9,'25 - Jun 15,'25)	6590
Sale in Week-3	(Jun 16,'25 - Jun 22,'25)	1315
Sale in Week-4	(Jun 2,'23 - Jun 29,'25)	3030
Sale in Week-5	(Jun 30,'25 - Jul 6,'25)	3635
Sale in Week-6	(Jul 7,'25- Jul 13,'25)	11300
Sale in Week-7	(Jul 14,'25- Jul 20,'25)	1490
Sale in Week-8	(Jul 21,'25- Jul 27,'25)	430
Sale in Week-9	(Jul 28,'25- Aug 3,'25)	4640
Sale in Week-10	(Aug 4,'25- Aug 10,'25)	1120
Sale in Week-11	(Aug 11,'25- Aug 17,'25)	1330
Sale in Week-12	(Aug 18,'25- Aug 24,'25)	2445

Fig1: Total revenue per week

2.3. Method for Profit and Margin Analysis:

To move beyond simple sales volume and understand true business health, a Profit Analysis was conducted. This examined the relationship between revenue, cost, and profitability.

Calculations done in Analysis:

- **Gross Profit Margin:** This formula was used to identify which products contribute most to earnings versus those that simply generate volume.

$$\text{Gross Profit Margin} = \frac{\text{Gross Profit}}{\text{Sales}} \times 100$$

2.4. Method for Inventory Classification :

To solve the problem of overstocking and dead stock, an **ABC Analysis** was performed. This inventory categorization technique divides items into three categories (A, B, and C) based on their revenue contribution.

Process:

- **Class A (High Value):** Items contributing to the top 75% of revenue.
- **Class B (Moderate Value):** Items contributing to the next 20% of revenue.
- **Class C (Low Value):** Items contributing to the bottom 5% of revenue.

We can use If condition in Excel for segmentation and a pareto chart for visual representation.

Name of the Item	Total Sales per Item	%	Cumulative %	Category
Hamper-4(large)	₹ 8,000.00	20.08284172	20.0828417	=IF(E28<=75, "A", IF(E28<=95, "B", "C"))
andles(pack of 4)-Sma	₹ 5,500.00	13.80695368	33.8897954	A
andles(pack of 4)-Larg	₹ 4,600.00	11.54763399	45.4374294	A
Hamper-2(Small)	₹ 3,800.00	9.539349818	54.9767792	A
Hamper-1 (Mini)	₹ 3,700.00	9.288314296	64.2650935	A
Hamper-3(medium)	₹ 3,500.00	8.786243253	73.0513368	A
candle-Type1	₹ 2,760.00	6.928580394	79.9799172	B

Fig2 : IF condition formula

2.5. Method for COD and Logistics Analysis

A specific subset of data focused on the reliability of payment methods to quantify the "sunk costs" associated with delivery.

Metrics Tracked:

- **Total COD Orders:** The number of orders placed with "Cash on Delivery".
- **Failure Rate Calculation:**

$$FailureRate = \frac{TotalCODCancelled}{TotalCODOrders} \times 100$$

- We Tried collecting data using google forms for reasons for cancellations and review. But the form had very little response and hence was not useful for analysis.

2.6. Method for Strategic Analysis:

To transition from raw data to actionable business strategies, a **SWOT Analysis** (Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, Threats) was conducted. This qualitative framework was selected to provide a holistic view of B-Stories' operational standing by integrating internal performance metrics with external market realities.

1. Data Collection Process:

- **Internal Factors (Strengths & Weaknesses):** These were derived from the quantitative findings of the financial analysis (e.g., high margins on hampers) and operational interviews with the business owner regarding production capacity and logistics.
- **External Factors (Opportunities & Threats):** These were identified through market research, specifically analyzing competitor activities on Instagram, changes in social media algorithms, and logistics cost trends in the e-commerce sector.

3 Results and Findings

3.1. Financial Overview:

The financial analysis of the 12-week period (June – August 2025) reveals a business with high potential but extreme volatility.

- **Total Revenue: ₹ 39,835.00** (Total generated in 12 weeks).
- **Average Weekly Revenue: ₹ 3,319.58**
- **Maximum Weekly Revenue: ₹ 11,300.00** (Occurred in Week 6).
- **Minimum Weekly Revenue: ₹ 430.00** (Occurred in Week 8).
- **Standard Deviation: ₹ 3,048.72**

The standard deviation is nearly equal to the average revenue, indicating massive instability. The business is heavily reliant on Peak Weeks, with revenue crashing to as low as ₹430 during non-event weeks.

STATISTICS Per Week	
Mean	₹ 3,319.58
Max	₹ 11,300.00
Min	₹ 430.00
Median	₹ 2,477.50
Std.Dev	₹ 3,048.72

Fig3: Statistics of the data

3.2. Time-Series Analysis:

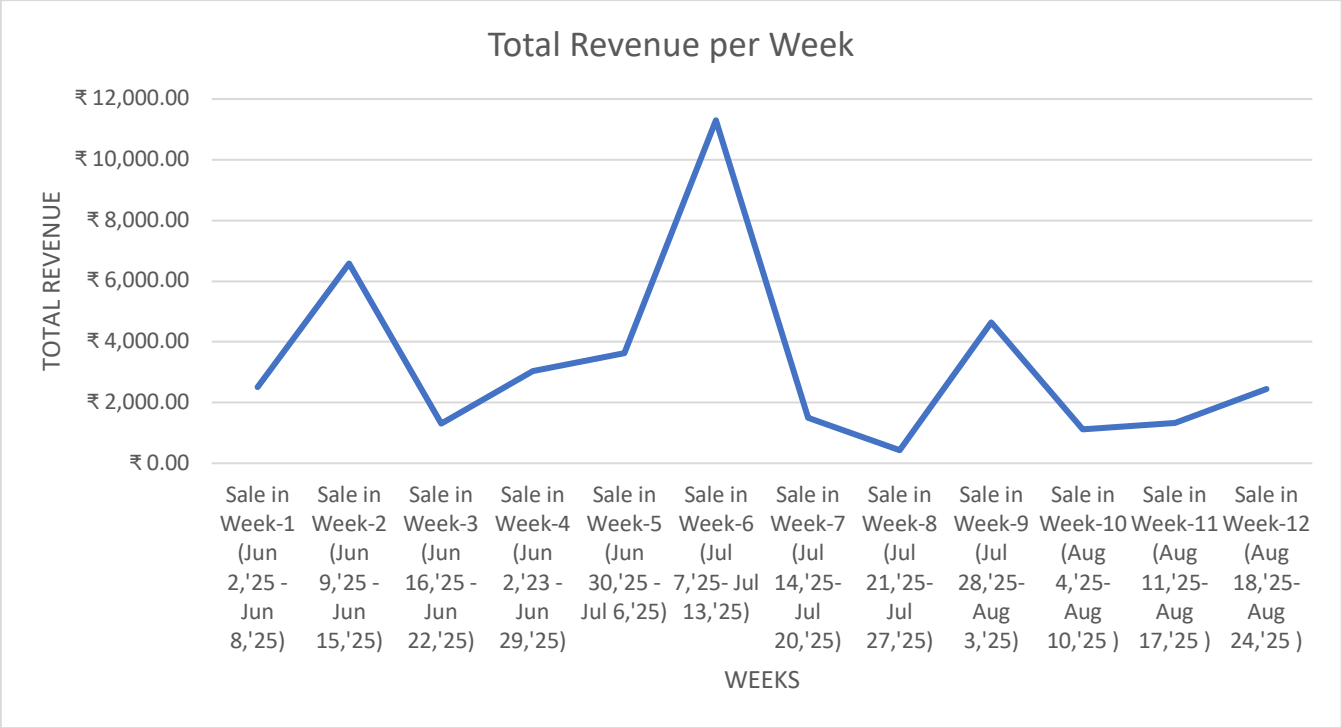

Fig 4: Total weekly sales chart

The time series chart reveals a distinct, volatile sales pattern characterized by a relatively low baseline interrupted by massive spikes in revenue. Instead of steady linear growth, the graph displays a pulse-like pattern where standard weekly revenue generally hovers between ₹400 and ₹3,500. This baseline is punctuated by three clear anomalies occurring in Week 2, Week 6, and Week 9. Among these, Week 6 emerges as the standout performer, reaching approximately ₹11,500—nearly six times higher than the calculated average of a normal

week (~₹1,922). Even the smallest of these peaks, Week 9, generated roughly ₹4,500, which is still more than double the average baseline performance, underscoring the massive impact of these specific event-driven periods. This is due to the Pop stores set upped during those weeks. To understand the true day-to-day health of the business, the analysis separates the Pop-up store weeks from the Regular sales, offering a realistic view:

Mean	₹ 1,922.78
Min	₹ 430.00
Max	₹ 3,635.00
Standar Deviation	₹ 1,034.17
Median	₹ 1,490.00

Fig5: Statistics without peaks(pop-up stores)

Excluding these peaks reveals a baseline mean of ₹1,922, establishing roughly ₹1,900 per week as the benchmark for the business. However, the data also highlights significant volatility; with a standard deviation of ₹1,034 relative to the mean, sales remain highly unpredictable even during standard weeks, fluctuating between a low of ₹430 and a high of ₹3,635.

3.3. Profit Analysis:

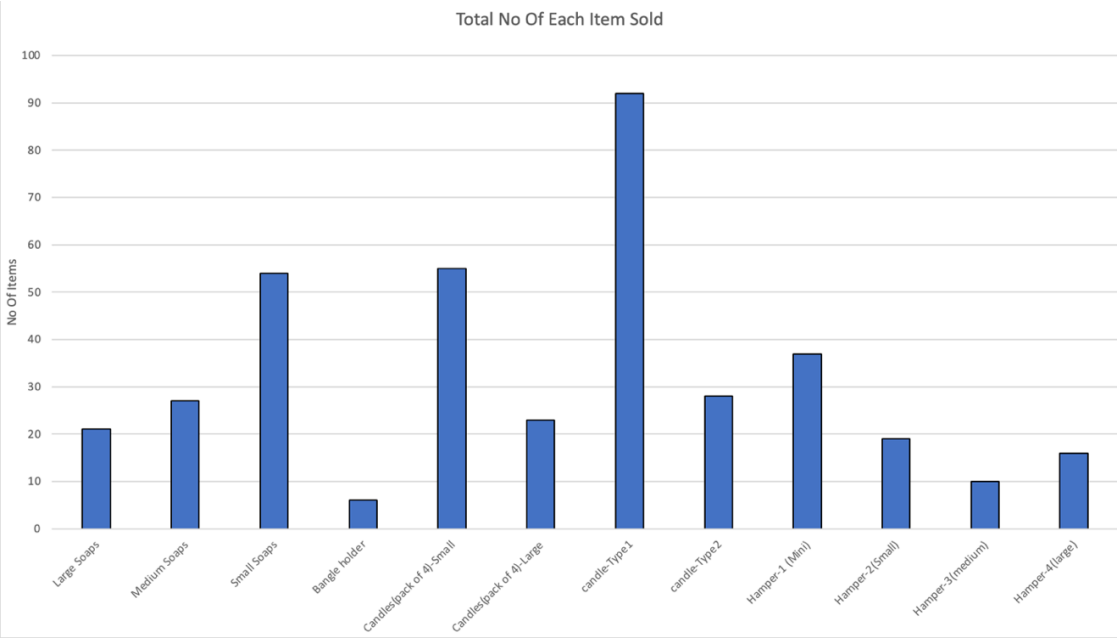

Fig6: Total No of items sold of each product in 12 weeks

From the above bar chart, we can see that candle type-1(Rs 30) is the most sold product. Whereas the Bangle holder, Hamper-3(medium) and Hamper-4(large) are the slow movers.

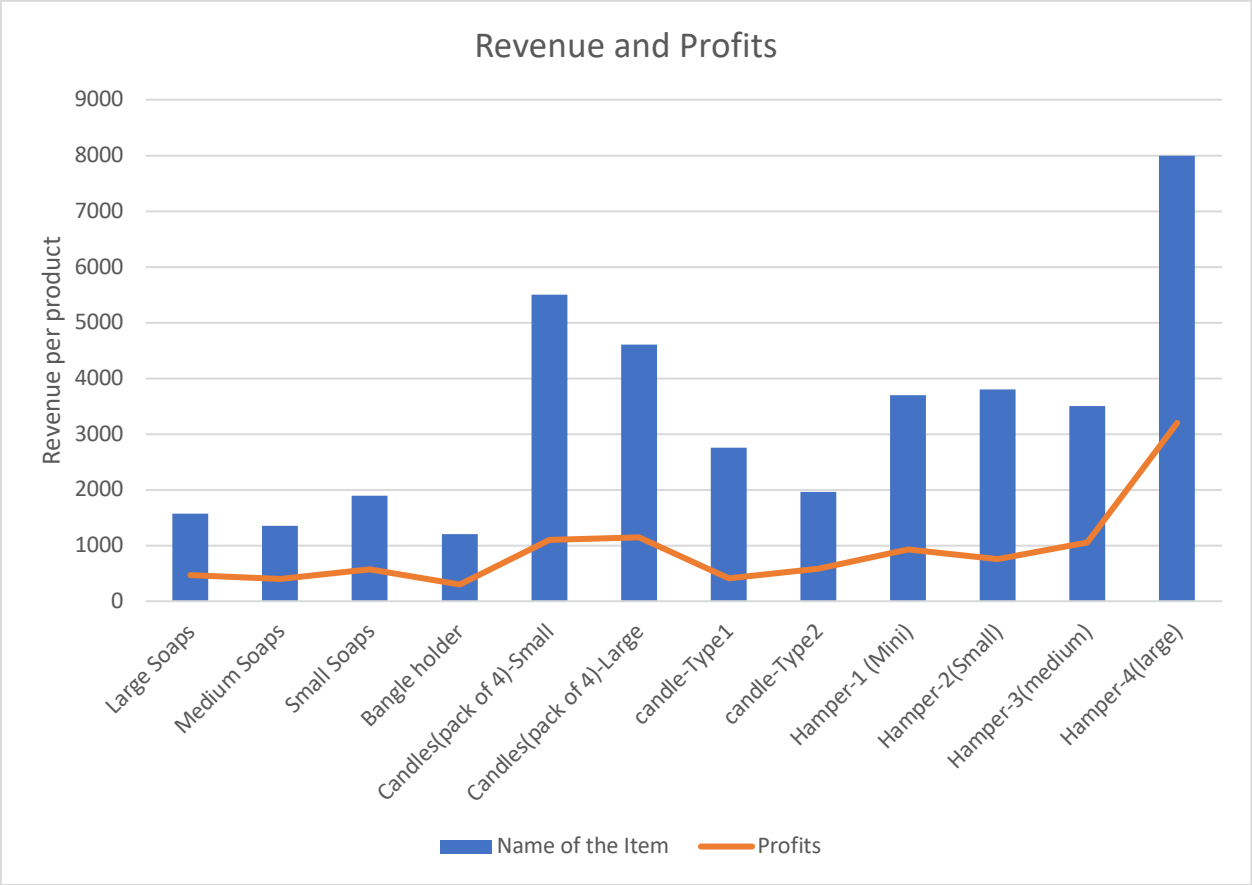

Fig7: Profits and revenue from each product in the span of 12 weeks.

But after referring to profit analysis chart, we can conclude that though hamper-4, hamper-3 sell in less in number they contribute well towards the revenue. Thus, Bangle holder is the product that has to be less stocked or made on order basis.

The analysis of revenue and profit data reveals that **Hamper-4 (Large)** is the most profitable product, contributing the highest share to overall revenue. **Candle packs** also show strong performance, indicating steady demand and healthy margins. In contrast, **soaps and bangle holders** generate lower sales and profits, reflecting limited market response. Overall, the trend shows a positive relationship between revenue and profit, suggesting that product pricing and cost structures are consistent. These insights highlight the need to prioritize high-performing items like hampers and candles while minimizing investment in low-margin products.

3.4. ABC Analysis:

For more detailed stock management ABC analysis is performed on the data.

Name of the Item	Total Sales per Item	%	Cumulative %	Category
Hamper-4(large)	₹ 8,000.00	20.08284172	20.0828417	A
Candles(pack of 4)-Smal	₹ 5,500.00	13.80695368	33.8897954	A
Candles(pack of 4)-Large	₹ 4,600.00	11.54763399	45.4374294	A
Hamper-2(Small)	₹ 3,800.00	9.539349818	54.9767792	A
Hamper-1 (Mini)	₹ 3,700.00	9.288314296	64.2650935	A
Hamper-3(medium)	₹ 3,500.00	8.786243253	73.0513368	A
candle-Type1	₹ 2,760.00	6.928580394	79.9799172	B
candle-Type2	₹ 1,960.00	4.920296222	84.9002134	B
Small Soaps	₹ 1,890.00	4.744571357	89.6447847	B
Large Soaps	₹ 1,575.00	3.953809464	93.5985942	B
Medium Soaps	₹ 1,350.00	3.388979541	96.9875737	C
Bangle holder	₹ 1,200.00	3.012426258	100	C

Fig8: ABC analysis performed for the products

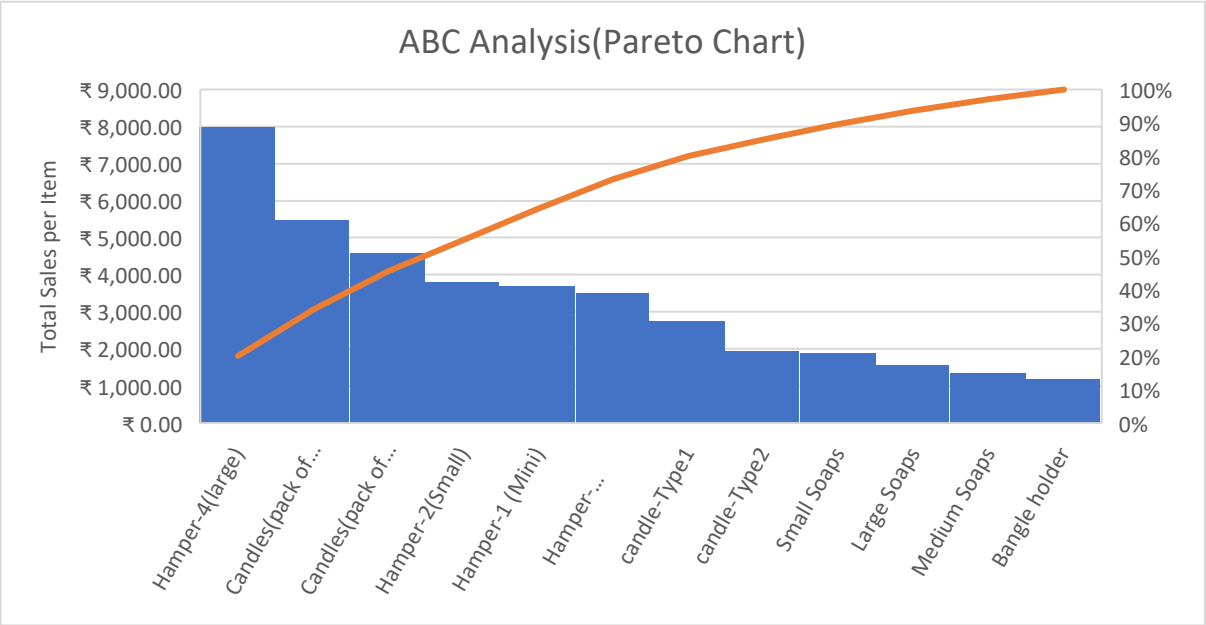

Fig9: Pareto chart on ABC analysis

- **Category A (High Priority - Top 75% Revenue):**
  - **Hamper-4 (Large):** Total Revenue ₹8,000 (Highest Earner)
  - **Candles (Pack of 4) - Small & Large:** Total Revenue ₹10,100 combined.
  - **Hamper-2 (Small) & Hamper-1 (Mini):** Consistently high contributors.
  - Gift Hampers and Candle Packs are the financial backbone of the business.
- **Category B (Moderate Priority - Next 20%):**
  - Candle Type-1 & Type-2
  - Small and large Soaps
- **Category C (Low Priority - Bottom 5%):**

- **Bangle Holder:** Total Revenue ₹1,200 (Lowest performer among major items).
- **Medium Soaps:** Low revenue contribution relative to stock effort.

3.5. ABC Analysis (during popup stores):

For a detailed information on inventory ,we need to analyse the products during pop-up stores(peaks), so that it will be easier for the owner to restock only the required products, thus we can remove slow movers and replace them with revenue generator to increase profits. for this we will perform ABC analysis for the weeks 2,6, and 9(pop-up store's weeks).

Name of the Item	Sale in Week-2 (Jun 9,'25 - Jun 15,'25)	Sale in Week-6 (Jul 7,'25- Jul 13,'25)	Sale in Week-9 (Jul 28,'25- Aug 3,'25)	Total Sales per Item
Large Soaps	150	300	300	750
Medium Soaps	200	350	100	650
Small Soaps	350	140	350	840
Bangle holder	0	0	200	200
Candles(pack of 4)-Sma	600	1000	1300	2900
Candles(pack of 4)-Larg	1000	1200	600	2800
candle-Type1	450	300	450	1200
candle-Type2	490	560	140	1190
Hamper-1 (Mini)	500	1000	500	2000
Hamper-2(Small)	800	400	200	1400
Hamper-3(medium)	1050	1050	0	2100
Hamper-4(large)	1000	5000	500	6500
TOTAL SALES per we	**6590**	**11300**	**4640**	

Fig10: Sales Data during the pop-up stores

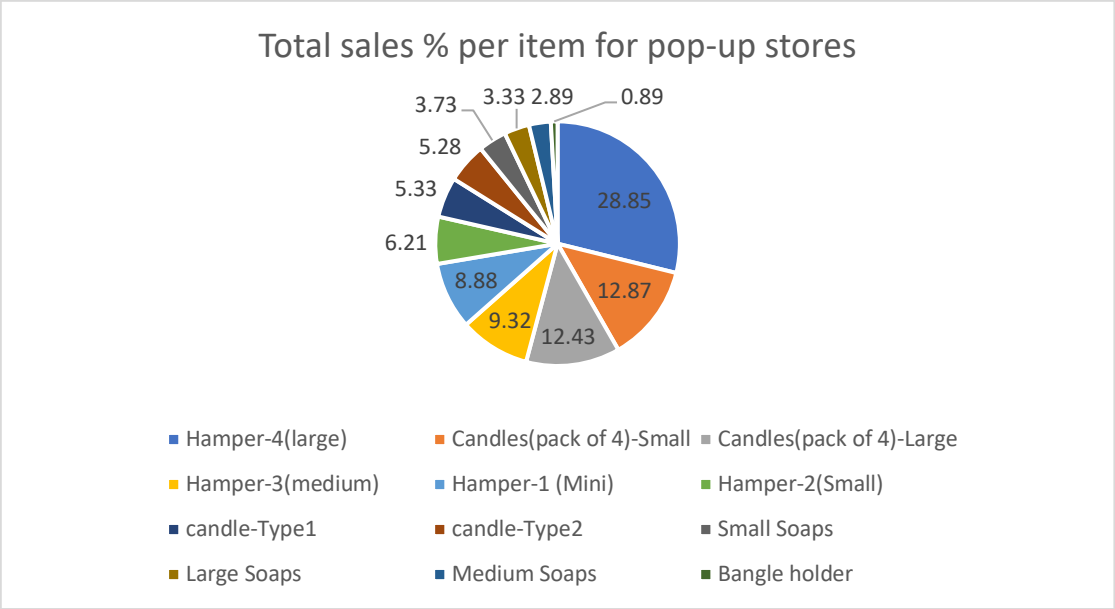

Fig11 : Pie chart on Distribution of Revenue during Pop-Up stores

Name of the Item	Total Sales per Item	%		
Hamper-4(large)	6500	28.85042166	28.85042	A
Candles(pack of 4)-Small	2900	12.87172659	41.72215	A
Candles(pack of 4)-Large	2800	12.42787395	54.15002	A
Hamper-3(medium)	2100	9.320905459	63.47093	A
Hamper-1 (Mini)	2000	8.877052818	72.34798	A
Hamper-2(Small)	1400	6.213936973	78.56192	B
candle-Type1	1200	5.326231691	83.88815	B
candle-Type2	1190	5.281846427	89.17	B
Small Soaps	840	3.728362184	92.89836	B
Large Soaps	750	3.328894807	96.22725	C
Medium Soaps	650	2.885042166	99.11229	C
Bangle holder	200	0.887705282	100	C
	22530			

Fig : ABC analysis for products during peaks

We can see from ABC analysis that Hampers and candles contribute highest to the revenue (A-category). The owner provides hampers to delegates/chief guests of the event .On the other hand, Soaps and bangle holders are the least sellers(C-category).It is best to exclude the bangle holder and focus more in the hampers and the candle packs.

3.6. COD Analysis:

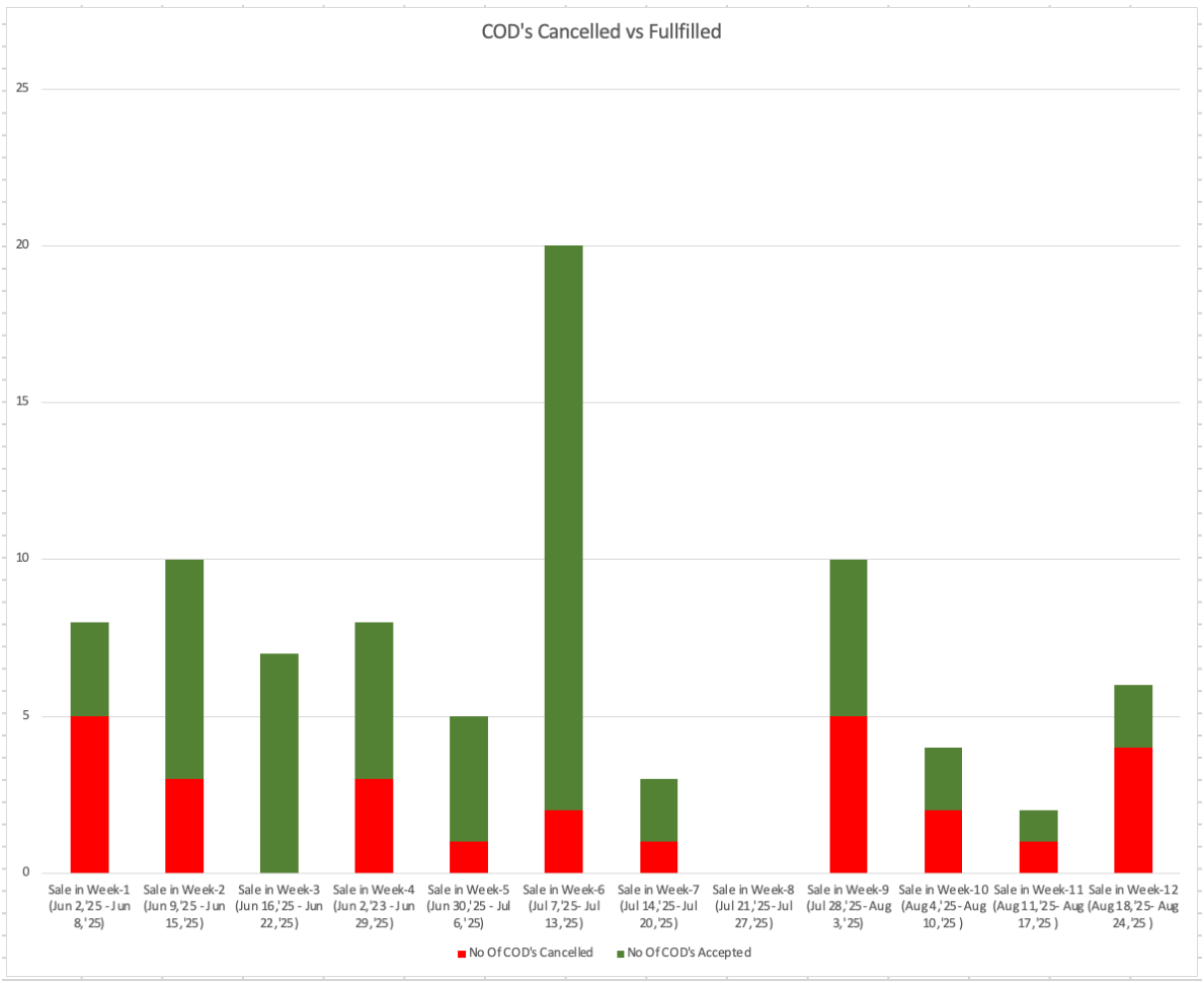

Fig12: COD'S Cancelled vs Fulfilled

From the above stacked bar chart, we can conclude that on an average more than 20% of CODs are getting cancelled. We can see high acceptance rate in week-2, week-6 and week-9, This was due to orders taken at the pop stores, where we know customers will pay. In these 12 weeks there were 27 orders cancelled. So, the Failure rate is 32.53%.This percent may seem negligible but for a small company it recurs a lot of loss , even if we estimate at least 100rs for delivery, the loss (rs.2700) is more than most of the week's revenue.

3.7. SWOT Analysis:

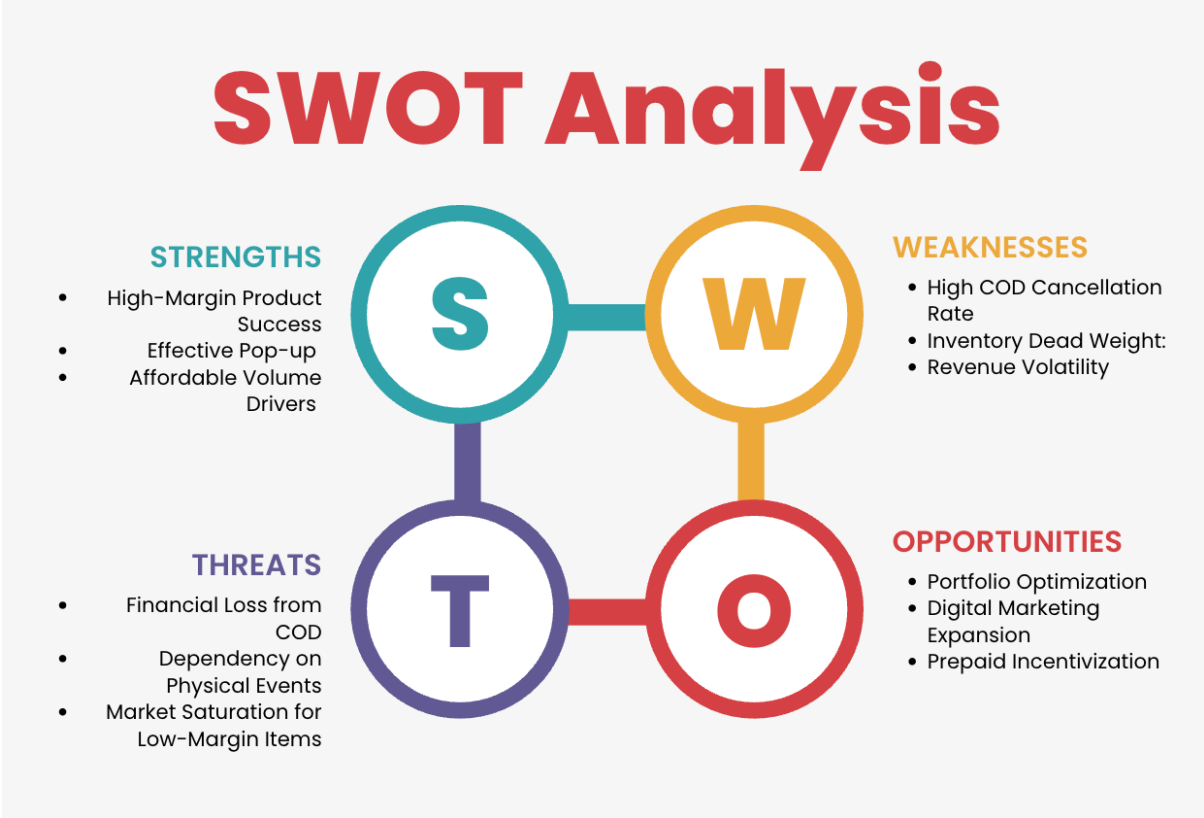

Fig13 : SWOT Analysis

1. **Strengths (Internal & Positive)**

- **High-Margin Product Success:** The business has identified Hamper-4 (Large) as a star product; despite lower sales volume, it contributes the highest share to overall revenue and yields a 40% profit margin.
- **Effective Pop-up Stores:** The business demonstrates a strong ability to generate revenue through physical presence. Peaks in sales occurred specifically in Weeks 2, 6, and 9, which coincided with pop-up stores set up at college fests.
- **Affordable Volume Drivers:** Candle-Type1 (priced at ₹30) acts as a volume driver, being the most sold product (92 units) over the 12-week period, ensuring customer acquisition.

2. **Weaknesses (Internal & Negative)**

- **High COD Cancellation Rate:** There is a significant operational inefficiency regarding Cash-on-Delivery (COD) orders. On average, more than **20% of COD orders are cancelled**, leading to potential logistics losses.
- **Inventory Dead Weight:** Certain products, specifically Bangle holders and Medium Soaps, are identified as slow movers with limited market response, tying up capital.
- **Revenue Volatility:** The business suffers from highly inconsistent income. The standard deviation of weekly sales is ₹3,048, which is nearly as high as the average weekly sales (₹3,319), indicating a lack of stable recurring revenue.

3. **Opportunities (External & Positive)**

- **Portfolio Optimization:** There is a clear opportunity to shift focus and capital towards high-performing items like Hamper-4 and Candle packs while moving slow items like Bangle holders to an on-order basis to reduce inventory costs.

- **Digital Marketing Expansion:** Addressing the problem of different marketing strategies and platforms is listed as a future step; executing this could smooth out the revenue dips observed during non-event weeks (e.g., Week 8 saw only ₹430 in sales).
- **Prepaid Incentivization:** With an average of only 2 prepaid orders per week versus 7 COD orders, implementing incentives (discounts/freebies) for prepaid payments could drastically reduce the 20% cancellation rate.

4. Threats (External & Negative)

- **Financial Loss from COD:** The losses from Cash-on-Delivery (COD) rejections are a direct threat to profitability, particularly given the small scale of the business.
- **Dependency on Physical Events:** The business is heavily reliant on pop-up stores for peak revenue. If these events (college fests) are cancelled or have low attendance, the business sees drastic revenue drops (as seen in the non-event weeks).
- **Market Saturation for Low-Margin Items:** The analysis notes that soaps generate lower sales and profits due to "limited market response," suggesting a competitive or saturated market for these specific generic items.

4 Interpretation of Results and Recommendations

4.1. Financial Health: The Event-Dependency Risk

The financial analysis paints a picture of a business that is viable but dangerously unstable. The total revenue of ₹39,835 over 12 weeks yields an average of ₹3,319 per week, but this average is misleading.

- The standard deviation of ₹3,048 is nearly equal to the average weekly revenue. This statistical anomaly indicates that there is no normal week for B-Stories. The business swings from extreme highs (₹11,300 in Week 6) to extreme lows (₹430 in Week 8).
- The business currently generates ~28% of its entire quarterly revenue in a single week (Week 6). If a pop-up event is cancelled due to rain or external factors, the business lacks a stable financial floor to cover fixed costs.
- The primary objective for the next quarter must be to raise the *minimum* weekly revenue baseline from ₹430 to ₹1,500. This reduces reliance on luck and external events.

4.2. Inventory Optimization: Implementing the ABC Framework

The ABC analysis provided a mathematical basis for restructuring the supply chain. Currently, capital is being tied up in the wrong places.

- Category A :Items: *Hamper-4 (Large), Candles (Pack of 4), Hamper-2 (Small).* These items are the Vital Few. They contribute to the top 70% of the revenue.

Implement a Safety Stock: B-Stories must never run out of materials for Hamper-4. If demand surges during a non-event week, these items must be ready to ship immediately to capture impulse buys.

- Category C :Items: *Bangle Holder, Large Soaps (Individual).* The Bangle Holder generated only ₹1,200 in 12 weeks .

Transition these immediately to a "Make-to-Order" (MTO) workflow. Do not keep finished stock. Keep only the raw materials. This frees up cash flow to buy more wax and fragrances for the Category A candles.

4.3. Logistics Strategy: Solving the COD Crisis

The finding that **32.53% of COD orders** are cancelled is the most critical operational red flag. In e-commerce, a good cancellation rate is typically 5-10%. B-Stories is operating at three times that risk level.

- For every 3 COD orders shipped, 1 comes back. This means the profit from the first successful order is completely wiped out by the return shipping costs of the third failed order. The business is essentially working for free on every third transaction.
- Solution: Implement a "Shipping Fee Deposit" policy.
    - Customers who want COD must pay a small deposit (e.g., ₹50 or the shipping cost) via UPI to confirm the order. The balance is paid on delivery.
    - This acts as a "commitment trade " ,A customer who pays even ₹10 is psychologically committed to the purchase and will rarely reject the delivery. This simple step could reduce the rejection rate.

4.4. Strategic Marketing and business recommendations:

B-stories operates through WhatsApp and Instagram where we have to dm to place order, we can scale the business using Shopify and advertisements. Creating a minimalist Shopify website would be easier for customers to see all the products at place and to place orders. We can increase business visibility by running insta advertisements.

In India giving return gifts in functions is a tradition. B-stories has a huge market in this sector. B-stories must do ground work and find collaborations with event managers and catering services. This way we can scale the business from small scale to medium or even large.

To scale beyond the Pop-up dependency, B-Stories needs to use some marketing tricks to drive online sales. Based on the data, here are some strategies:

- Stock Clearance Technique:

  Large Soaps and bangle holders (Category C) are not selling well individually.so we can Stop selling them individually. Instead, we can create a "Mystery Gift Add-on" for ₹399 at checkout.

- Creating recurring customers(online customers) from Pop-up stores:

We can give the offline customers coupons for their next order online, thus creating a recuring customer base from pop-up stores. We can run a campaign at pop up store, where we record customer reviews on the products and keep posting them online.

5 Additional

Link: https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1rhtoUN4pfVbiRaVun5ZlJAgRHgE-58nf?usp=sharing